

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE TO

Hiring Your Executive HR Coach

5 Critical Questions Every HR Leader Must Ask

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Why These 5 Questions Matter

You've reached a pivotal point in your HR career. Perhaps you're stepping into a more strategic role, navigating complex organizational challenges, or positioning yourself for the C-suite. The decision to invest in executive coaching could be transformative—or it could be a costly disappointment.

The difference lies in asking the right questions before you commit.

In my 20+ years of HR leadership and executive coaching, I've seen talented professionals waste time and resources on coaching relationships that weren't the right fit. I've also witnessed remarkable transformations when executives find a coach who truly understands their world.

This guide will help you:

- Distinguish between qualified coaches and those with impressive credentials but limited HR experience
- Identify coaching methodologies that drive real business outcomes
- Set measurable success criteria for your coaching investment
- Evaluate engagement models that fit your schedule and goals
- Recognize red flags and green flags in coach selection

Whether you're evaluating your first coach or reconsidering your current coaching relationship, these five questions will help you make an informed decision that advances your career and delivers measurable value to your organization.

Let's begin.

Question 1

What's Your Coaching Methodology?

This is your first and most important filter. A coach's methodology reveals how they think, how they work, and what results you can expect.

Why This Question Matters

Different methodologies drive different outcomes. Some coaches focus on exploration and self-discovery. Others emphasize action and accountability. Neither is wrong—but one might be right for you.

Red flags to watch for:

- Vague answers like "I use an integrative approach" without specifics
- Over-reliance on assessments without practical application
- "One-size-fits-all" programs without customization

Green flags to look for:

- Clear explanation of their approach (e.g., "I use Gestalt methodology combined with Ericksonian coaching")
- Evidence-based practices with real-world HR applications
- Customization based on your specific goals and challenges

What to Ask Next

- "Can you walk me through a typical coaching session?"
- "How do you balance exploration with action?"
- "How would you adapt your methodology for my specific situation?"

Real-World Example

An HR Director once told me she spent six months with a coach who focused exclusively on "mindfulness and presence." While valuable, it didn't address her immediate need: positioning HR as a strategic partner at the executive table. When we started working together using a results-driven methodology, she secured her first board presentation within two months.

Question 2

What's Your HR Background?

This question separates coaches who understand your world from those who don't. HR leadership is unique—you're navigating business strategy, people dynamics, legal compliance, and organizational politics simultaneously.

Why HR Experience Matters

Imagine explaining to a coach why your brilliant talent strategy was blocked by budget constraints, why your DEI initiative faces resistance from senior leaders, or why you can't just "fire the toxic employee" due to legal complexities. A coach without HR experience won't immediately grasp these realities.

You don't have time to educate your coach about HR fundamentals. You need someone who can hit the ground running.

What "Real HR Experience" Looks Like

Look for coaches who have:

- Held HR leadership positions (not just HR generalist roles)
- Led teams and reported to C-suite executives
- Managed organizational change initiatives
- Navigated complex stakeholder relationships
- Balanced strategic thinking with operational excellence

Questions to ask:

- *"What was your most senior HR role?"*
- *"Can you share an example of a challenge you faced that's similar to mine?"*
- *"How long have you been coaching HR professionals specifically?"*

The Credential Trap

Coaching certifications (ICF, Erickson, etc.) are valuable—they demonstrate commitment to the profession. But credentials alone don't guarantee your coach understands the HR landscape. Look for the combination of coaching expertise AND HR leadership experience.

Question 3

How Do You Measure Success?

This is where transformation separates from feel-good sessions. If a coach can't clearly articulate how they measure success, you're gambling with your time and money.

Why Metrics Matter in Coaching

You're an HR leader—you understand the importance of KPIs, ROI, and measurable outcomes. Your coaching engagement should be no different. Whether you're investing personal funds or company resources, you deserve to know what success looks like.

Effective coaching metrics include:

- Clear, written goals established in session 1
- Progress reviews at regular intervals (30/60/90 days)
- Specific behavioral changes or skill development
- Business outcomes (promotions, expanded influence, successful initiatives)
- 360-degree feedback or stakeholder input

Red Flags

Be cautious if a coach says:

- "Success is different for everyone" (without providing a framework)
- "We'll know it when we see it"
- "The real value is in the journey, not the destination"

These answers aren't necessarily wrong, but they lack the accountability structure you need for a significant investment.

Setting Your Own Success Criteria

Before your discovery call, define what success looks like for you:

- What do you want to be doing differently in 3 months?
- What business outcome would make this investment worthwhile?
- How will you and others know you've grown?

A good coach will help you refine these goals and create accountability structures around them.

Question 4

What's Your Engagement Model?

The structure of your coaching relationship significantly impacts results. Understanding a coach's engagement model helps you determine if it fits your schedule, working style, and commitment level.

Common Engagement Models

1. Intensive Programs (3-6 months)

- Best for: Major transitions, skill development, career advancement
- Frequency: Bi-weekly or weekly sessions
- Investment: Higher upfront, but often yields faster results

2. Ongoing Support (6-12 months)

- Best for: Leadership development, strategic positioning, complex challenges
- Frequency: Monthly or bi-monthly sessions
- Investment: Spread over time, allows for sustained growth

3. Project-Based Coaching

- Best for: Specific initiatives (merger integration, culture change, restructuring)
- Frequency: Flexible based on project demands
- Investment: Tied to project milestones

What to Consider

Session length and frequency:

- 60-minute sessions: Good for maintenance and check-ins
- 90-minute sessions: Better for deep work and breakthrough moments

Between-session support:

- Email access for quick questions?
- Emergency session availability?
- Resources, assessments, or tools included?

Questions to Ask

- *"What does your typical engagement timeline look like?"*
- *"How flexible are you if I need to reschedule?"*
- *"What support do you provide between our scheduled sessions?"*
- *"Can we adjust the engagement model as my needs evolve?"*

Question 5

Can You Share Client Results?

This is your proof of concept. A coach's past results are the best predictor of your future outcomes. Look for specific, measurable achievements—not just testimonials that say "Gordana was wonderful to work with."

What Great Results Look Like

Specific examples you should ask for:

- Career advancement: "Helped an HR Manager become HR Director within 8 months"
- Strategic positioning: "Client went from operational focus to presenting quarterly business reviews to the board"
- Skill development: "Executive improved stakeholder engagement scores by 40% in 6 months"
- Business impact: "Led successful organizational restructuring affecting 500+ employees"

Reading Between the Lines

Pay attention to:

- Timeframes: How quickly did clients see results?
- Similarity: Do the examples match your situation and goals?
- Specificity: Are outcomes vague ("increased confidence") or concrete ("secured seat at strategy meetings")?
- Challenges: Can they articulate obstacles faced and how they were overcome?

The Reference Call

If you're seriously considering a coach, ask to speak with 1-2 past or current clients. This is standard practice. A coach who hesitates may not have strong results to share (or may not have proper client permission for references).

Questions for references:

- *"What was your situation before coaching, and what changed?"*
- *"How would you describe the coach's style and approach?"*
- *"Was the investment worth it? Would you do it again?"*
- *"What surprised you most about the coaching process?"*

Self-Assessment Worksheet

Use this worksheet to evaluate potential coaches. Rate each area on a scale of 1-5, with 5 being the highest.

Criteria	Coach A	Coach B
Clear, evidence-based methodology	_____	_____
Relevant HR leadership experience	_____	_____
Measurable success criteria defined	_____	_____
Engagement model fits my needs	_____	_____
Demonstrated client results	_____	_____
Strong references available	_____	_____
Chemistry and trust established	_____	_____
Investment aligns with value	_____	_____
TOTAL SCORE (out of 40)	_____	_____

Scoring Guide:

- 32-40: Excellent fit—move forward with confidence
- 24-31: Good potential—address any concerns before committing
- 16-23: Proceed with caution—significant gaps exist
- Below 16: Keep looking—this coach isn't the right fit

About the Author

Gordana Panajotović, PCC ICF

Gordana brings a rare combination to executive coaching: 20+ years of HR leadership experience and advanced coaching credentials. She understands the challenges HR executives face because she's lived them—from managing teams of 5 to leading strategic HR initiatives for organizations with 1,000+ employees.



Professional Credentials:

- PCC ICF (Professional Certified Coach, International Coach Federation)
- Professional Certified Erickson Coach
- Certified NLP Trainer (IA-NLP Switzerland, IN-NLP Germany)
- Gestalt Psychotherapy Training (EAPTI-SEB Belgrade)
- Master's Degree in Human Resources Management

Leadership Experience:

- Director of Customer Care & Contact Center Operations (UNIQA Insurance)
- Director of Procurement, Logistics & General Affairs
- Learning Business Partner (NCR Corporation - Global)
- Director of International Recruitment Agency (ITJobs)

Gordana founded Eagle Smart - Center for Leadership in 2012 and has since coached 100+ HR professionals, delivered 2,000+ hours of training, and published 50+ articles on leadership and management skills.

Her coaching approach combines practical HR expertise with evidence-based coaching methodologies, focusing on measurable outcomes and real-world business impact.

Ready to Take the Next Step?

You now have the framework to evaluate executive coaches effectively. You understand what questions to ask, what results to expect, and what red flags to avoid.

The next step is simple: start the conversation.

Book a Free Consultation

I offer complimentary 30-minute discovery calls to HR leaders considering executive coaching. This is your opportunity to:

- Ask me any of the five questions from this guide
- Discuss your specific goals and challenges
- Determine if we're a good fit to work together
- Get clarity on next steps—no pressure, no obligation

Schedule Your Free Consultation

Connect With Me

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"The best investment you can make is in yourself."

— Warren Buffett